(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

Cardiovascular disease

Cardiovascular disease (CVD) is the name for a group of conditions that affect your heart and blood vessels. It can often be prevented by having a healthy lifestyle or taking medicines if you need them.

Easy Read

Keep your heart healthy (British Heart Foundation website, PDF only, 15.45MB) (Link: https://www.bhf.org.uk/-/media/images/information-support/publications/easy-reads/keep-your-heart-healthy-easy-read/020824_keepyourhearthealthyer_publication.pdf)

Symptoms of cardiovascular disease (CVD)

Symptoms of cardiovascular disease (CVD) will depend on the condition you have. Some conditions may not have any symptoms.

For some people, the first sign that they have CVD may be having chest pain (angina (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/angina/)), a heart attack (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/heart-attack/) or stroke (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/stroke/).

Types of cardiovascular disease (CVD)

Cardiovascular disease (CVD) is a name for a group of conditions that affect your heart and blood vessels. There are many different types of CVD.

Do not try to diagnose your condition yourself.

Main types of CVD

Condition	What the condition is
Coronary heart disease (CHD)	The arteries become blocked by a build-up of fat, making it hard for blood to flow to and from your heart.
Peripheral arterial disease (PAD)	A build-up of fat in the arteries causes reduced blood flow to the legs and feet.
Aortic disease	A group of conditions that affect the aorta (the largest blood vessel in the body). It can lead to an abdominal aortic aneurysm.
Stroke	Blood suddenly stops flowing to a part of your brain because of a blockage. This can affect things like speech and movement.

Who's at risk of cardiovascular disease (CVD)

Cardiovascular disease (CVD) is often caused by a build-up of fat in the arteries. This makes it hard for blood to flow through your body and can lead to a blood clot.

There are things that may make it more likely you'll get CVD, including:

- your lifestyle – such as smoking, drinking too much alcohol, being overweight and not being active
- your age – CVD mainly affects people over 50 years old
- your sex – men are more likely to get CVD than women
- your ethnicity – you may be more likely to get CVD if you're from a South Asian, Black African or African Caribbean ethnic background
- having family members with CVD
- having certain conditions, such as diabetes (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/diabetes/), high blood pressure (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/high-blood-pressure/) or high cholesterol (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/high-cholesterol/)

See a GP if:

- you think you're at higher risk of having or getting cardiovascular disease (CVD)

Reducing your risk of cardiovascular disease (CVD)

Cardiovascular disease (CVD) is very common, and one of the main causes of death in the UK.

If you have a high chance of getting CVD you may be advised to take a medicine called statins (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/statins/). Statins lower the level of cholesterol in the blood and reduce the chance of getting CVD.

There are also lifestyle changes you can make to help prevent getting CVD or stop it getting worse if you already have it.

Do

- ✓ eat a healthy, balanced diet
- ✓ reduce the amount of fatty foods you eat
- ✓ try to exercise regularly
- ✓ try to keep to a healthy weight
- ✓ cut down on alcohol
- ✓ stop smoking if you smoke

Visit the NHS Better Health website for free tools and support to help you lose weight, get active, quit smoking and drink less (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/better-health/).

NHS Health Check

The NHS Health Check (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/nhs-health-check/) is a free check-up for people aged 40 to 74 to check the health of their heart and blood vessels. It can tell you if you're at higher risk of getting CVD.

Treatment for cardiovascular disease (CVD)

Treatment for cardiovascular disease (CVD) will depend on the condition you have.

Your treatment could include:

- medicines such as statins (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/statins/)
- surgery
- a device, such as a pacemaker

Your doctor may also recommend making lifestyle changes, such as losing weight or getting more exercise.

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